



36 |

“It is my belief that if Danone was twice as large, the world would have been a better place, and you cannot say that about every company”

anything as long it sits well with what we are capable of. My starting point is about making a difference with our distinctive capabilities... To be honest, the existing portfolio is good, but the opportunity is big, and we can grow well from here.

Q: What is your view on having an India-specific approach in a market that is known to be full of opportunities and yet complex?

A: India is a very different proposition. Technology is available everywhere and it is universal, but how you deliver it in each country is what makes it different. Tastes are different in India and come from diverse cuisines. You can't have a one-size-fits-all approach.

We are focussed on developing global platforms, such as gut health or protein that we can apply across our portfolio—examples are those of early life or medical nutrition... then we tailor these products to local tastes and preferences, **we call this glocalisation—global platforms executed in the right way locally.**

Q: The debate on dairy-based versus plant-based products continues. What is your take?

A: We have seen how plant-based nutrition has gained ground in Europe and North America... We have a great portfolio in both the beverages and yoghurts categories, with strong brands in both these markets. With the growth of flexitarian diets, there continues to be a lot of buzz around plant-based products. My view is that **both plant-based and dairy-based [products] will co-exist and there is no question of replacing one with the other.** For example, people may choose oat milk in their coffee and dairy in their tea.

Q: Technology is a potent tool in the hands of marketers today. What do you like about it?

A: It is a very formidable force. Technology is everywhere and a huge factor. I was in China earlier this year and saw 5G technology at work. What you can get from AI or, for that matter, just the data generated from the consumer is invaluable. If you can then use data mining over it, a lot more can be done.

Take the case of early life nutrition in China. We have an app where through our image recognition AI, you start getting very relevant information on stool consistency and colour. Danone is investing in developing such digital tools to help give parents peace of mind about the health and well-being of their little ones—particularly when it comes to their baby's nutrition and digestive health. I look at technology as being very useful to make lives easier, and I love it! **BT**

@krishnagopalan